

doctor wants to monitor your labor continuously, talk to them about how you can maintain some mobility; for example, by sitting on a birthing ball, or adopting an all-fours position on the bed or on a mattress on the floor.

Most units now use wireless technology, so you can move around as you wish without being constrained by the wires hooking you up to the machine.

Your pain relief options Factors that may influence the type of pain relief you would like include how active you want to be (see [An active labor](#)); what effect different drugs may have on how you experience labor, and how drugs can affect the baby.

Natural methods, such as breathing techniques, laboring in water, and TENS (see [Relaxation techniques](#)), and some medical pain-relief options, such as analgesics (see [Drugs for pain relief](#)), allow an active birth because you won't lose all feeling or muscle movement. However, systemic (IV) analgesics cross the placenta and can affect the baby's breathing at birth. Regional anesthetics, such as [epidurals](#), limit movement and can mean that you won't feel when you're pushing.

Making a birth plan

Writing your preferences in a birth plan helps consolidate your thoughts and to pass this information to your doctor. A birth plan is useful, too, for your birthing partner, who may need to advocate for you in labor. Birth plans also allow you to state any special needs, such as the help you will need if you have a disability.

Try to make your birth plan straightforward and accessible. Working with your caregivers as a team will help you feel involved in decision making, whatever the outcome.